There were countless bouquets of flowers waiting for me. Abhishek and Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, two of India's best-known Bollywood stars, dropped by to congratulate me and we happily relived the final all over again.

Looking back on it now, it still feels like a dream. Beating Australia, Pakistan and Sri Lanka in the course of one week to win the World Cup in front of huge Indian crowds just feels unreal. The television audience for our semi-final match against Pakistan, I was told, was the highest ever recorded in India's sporting history. I must confess that I continue to get goose bumps every time I think about that week.

On a personal note, I was pleased to have scored a total of 482 runs, the highest for India and the second highest in the tournament, at an average of 54 with two hundreds. I felt that I had proved to myself that after twenty-two years of examination at the very highest level, I was still good enough to carry on competing with the very best, that the hunger and the passion were still very much alive.

A number of my friends have asked me why I didn't retire from one-day cricket after winning the World Cup, as the summit had been scaled and there was nothing left for me to achieve. They may well have a point. It could indeed have been a grand exit. Emotions were running high and the timing could not have been better. But to be honest, such a thought never occurred to me. I wanted to remember the World Cup as a happy moment, and announcing my retirement straight after winning the trophy would have shifted the focus from the cup triumph to my retirement.

The Indian cricket team had stuck together through difficult times to make the world stage their own. Each player had made sacrifices and each one deserved to enjoy the moment. Cricket is a team sport and I feel immensely proud to have been part of the World Cup-winning team.

Finally, I had always wanted one memorable send-off from international cricket that I could never forget in my life. Multiple send-offs can end up diluting the significance of the event and that was not something I had ever wanted.

India in the 2011 World Cup

1st match, Group B. Bangladesh v India at Dhaka. 19 February 2011
India 370–4 (50/50 ov); Bangladesh 283–9 (50/50 ov)
India won by 87 runs